

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Religion without God - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Religion without God - Solved Practice Workbook

Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · Topic 07 A standalone practice document. It is designed to be worked without the learning session open beside it, and it repeats no teaching prose.

How to use this workbook

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** by a randomised, length-balanced assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; **the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

What is inside

Part	Content	Count
1	Core diagnostic MCQs	24
2	Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
-	Question-specific option explanations	128
-	Unique examiner traps	32
3	Verified previous-year questions, fully solved	7
4	Original solved Mains models (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)	6

Marking and timing conventions

- Word bands: 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words.
- Every model answer follows **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification**.
- Every model answer closes with a decided verdict, and the twenty-mark models additionally name the **defeater** that would change that verdict.
- **Standing penalties in this clause:** an answer with no stated definition of religion; "atheistic" written where "non-theistic" is meant; Cārvāka offered as an instance rather than as the limit; the Mīmāṃsā Veda called revelation; and any invented year for Smart, Feuerbach, Freud or Comte.

Terminology rule

English-first throughout. The English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit, Pali, German or Latin term follows in parentheses.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** by a randomised, length-balanced assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. The definition that decides the whole clause

Which kind of definition of religion, once adopted in an answer's opening lines, by itself settles whether religion without God is possible?

- A. A family-resemblance definition, which needs one feature that every member of the religious family must possess before it can classify at all.
- B. A substantive definition, which fixes religion by the kind of object affirmed and can therefore build a personal creator into the concept itself.
- C. A multidimensional definition, on which Smart's doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material dimensions are jointly compulsory.
- D. A functional definition, which fixes religion by orientation, practice, community and liberation and therefore rules non-theistic traditions out.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a family-resemblance account expressly denies that any single feature must be shared by every member, which is precisely why it cannot make belief in a creator necessary.
- **B:** Correct: substantive definitions identify religion by its object, so a God- centred version makes theism analytically necessary and decides the clause by stipulation rather than by evidence drawn from actual traditions.
- **C:** Incorrect: Smart's dimensions are the standard argument against creator- necessity, and belief in a creator God does not appear on his essential list at all, so this reverses the point of citing him.
- **D:** Incorrect: functional definitions do the opposite work, since orientation, practice, community and liberation are all available to Buddhism, Jainism and classical Mimamsa without any creator.

Examiner trap 1: Scripts that never state which definition of religion they are using lose the clause in the first paragraph; announce the definition, defend it in one line, then apply it consistently to every case you cite.

MCQ 2. Repairing an over-broad functionalism

A functional definition is challenged on the ground that it makes nationalism a religion. Which repair keeps the Indian non-theistic cases in and ideology out?

- A. Add a disciplined, socially embodied relation to an ultimate or sacred order together with a transformative or soteriological practice.
- B. Add that any commitment demanding sacrifice, generating solidarity and organising collective observance already counts as religious.
- C. Add a historical restriction confining religion to traditions founded before the modern period and possessing continuous institutional life.
- D. Add a requirement of belief in miracles or supernatural intervention, while leaving the question of a personal creator open for each tradition.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the owner's working sufficient cluster; the non-theistic traditions all possess a sacred order and a liberation-directed discipline, while commitments that merely supply meaning and belonging do not.
- **B:** Incorrect: this widens the definition further rather than narrowing it, because sacrifice, solidarity and a calendar of collective observance are exactly what nationalism already supplies.
- **C:** Incorrect: an age test tracks nothing conceptual, would admit ancient non-religious ideologies and would arbitrarily expel later religious movements that meet every substantive criterion.
- **D:** Incorrect: a miracle test is both too narrow, since Mimamsa's ritual efficacy is law-like rather than miraculous, and simply irrelevant to the over-breadth complaint that has been raised.

Examiner trap 2: Do not answer the nationalism objection by abandoning functionalism; the mark is earned by adding the sacred-order and soteriological conditions, not by retreating to a God-centred definition.

MCQ 3. The function that really does need a deity

On the owner's table of religious functions, which one most clearly does require a personal deity, so that a candid answer has to concede it?

- A. Liberation or salvation, since release from the human predicament must be bestowed by an agent who is genuinely able to grant it.
- B. Ritual efficacy, since an unseen potency released by correct performance cannot operate unless an intelligent agent supervises the sequence.
- C. Moral motivation, since obligation collapses into mere preference unless a commanding will attaches reward and punishment to conduct.
- D. Petitionary prayer, since a responsive addressee who can hear, choose and grant is built into the structure of petition itself.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: liberation as a generic function is exactly what nirvana, Jain liberation and Samkhya-Yoga isolation deliver without a creator; only grace in its personal-agency sense requires a giver.
- **B:** Incorrect: Mimamsa's unseen ritual potency (apurva) secures efficacy with no supervising agent at all, and Buddhist and Jain disciplines are held to be efficacious without one either.
- **C:** Incorrect: compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight and human flourishing all supply motivation here, and the full dependence question is routed to the Religion and Morality owner in any case.
- **D:** Correct: petition is relational by structure, so meditation, aspiration and recitation perform other work without being petition in the same sense; conceding this separates a strong script from a sweeping one.

Examiner trap 3: Answering that God is required for nothing whatever looks bolder but scores lower; name petition, grace and covenant as genuinely theistic goods and then show that religion as such does not depend on them.

MCQ 4. Non-theism, atheism and the firewall between them

Which statement draws the distinction between non-theism and atheism with the precision this clause demands?

- A. Non-theism denies every god, spirit and sacred being, while atheism denies only the single omnipotent creator of classical monotheistic religion.
- B. Non-theism means a creator is absent from a tradition's diagnosis and path, whereas atheism is the positive denial that God exists at all.
- C. Non-theism is a politer name for atheism, adopted so that Buddhism and Jainism can be described without giving needless offence to their living practitioners.
- D. Non-theism holds that God's existence is unknown or unknowable, while atheism merely suspends judgement until further evidence happens to arrive.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this inverts the scope of both terms, since the whole purpose of the non-theistic label is that it leaves lesser deities and devotional practice entirely untouched.
- **B:** Correct: the owner's firewall is that rejecting a creator does not entail denying every deity, sacred being, devotional act or transcendent value, so absence from the path and denial of existence are different claims.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction is doctrinal rather than diplomatic, since Theravada Buddhism admits cosmological gods while denying both their creatorhood and their salvific ultimacy.
- **D:** Incorrect: this swaps the standard definitions of agnosticism and atheism and then attaches the wrong one to non-theism, collapsing three separate positions into a single confusion.

Examiner trap 4: Writing 'Buddhism is atheistic' in the opening line concedes the theist's framing and invites the reply that a godless system cannot be a religion; write 'non-theistic' and state what the word leaves standing.

MCQ 5. Both deliverables of the agnosticism question

The 2023 question asks what agnosticism is and how agnostics conceptualise the relation between religion and God. Which answer supplies both halves?

- A. The claim that the word 'God' carries no determinate meaning, together with the view that the existence question cannot even be coherently formulated.
- B. Indifference to the question of God, together with the view that religion is an aesthetic preference comparable to a private taste in music or in painting.
- C. Suspension of judgement about God, subdivided into weak and strong forms, with continued valuing of religion's ethical and experiential dimensions.
- D. Denial of God's existence on evidential grounds, together with the view that religion is a purely social institution that carries no cognitive content whatever.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is the meaning-first position sometimes labelled ignosticism, whereas agnosticism accepts the question as intelligible and reports it to be unsettled or unsettleable.
- **B:** Incorrect: indifference is a fourth position that the owner tells you to keep apart from suspension of judgement, which is an epistemic stance held for stated reasons about evidence.
- **C:** Correct: the stem prints a definition task and a positional task, so the answer must define, sub-divide into 'not known' and 'unknowable', and then state the graded religiosity that withholds assent while retaining practice.
- **D:** Incorrect: denial is atheism rather than agnosticism, and the reduction of religion to a social institution is a further thesis that suspension of judgement does not by itself entail.

Examiner trap 5: Half-answers that define agnosticism and stop forfeit the second printed deliverable; the stem asks how agnostics relate religion and God, so the graded-religiosity paragraph is compulsory.

MCQ 6. Why the creator hypothesis is idle in Buddhism

In the Buddhist account, what makes the creator hypothesis explanatorily unnecessary for the problem the tradition sets itself?

- A. Dependent origination with karma explains how suffering arises from conditions and ceases when they go, so a maker adds no step to that sequence.
- B. The Buddha demonstrated by inference that no first cause of the world can exist, which closes the cosmological route to God permanently.
- C. The monastic community allocates karmic fruits to practitioners, taking over the task a divine superintendent would otherwise have to perform.
- D. Liberation itself functions as an impersonal first cause from which the conditioned world is derived, so the explanatory role is occupied.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: craving and ignorance condition suffering and the path removes the conditions, so a creator neither enters the diagnosis nor performs work in the cure, which makes the hypothesis idle rather than refuted.
- **B:** Incorrect: no such demonstration is claimed anywhere in the owner; the case is that the creator hypothesis is idle for the therapeutic problem, not that its impossibility has been proved.
- **C:** Incorrect: no community allocates karmic results in this account; the Sangha sustains practice and transmission, while the moral-causal order operates as law rather than as administration.
- **D:** Incorrect: nirvana is the goal of the path rather than a cosmological origin, and treating it as a first cause quietly reimports the very creator structure that Buddhism manages without.

Examiner trap 6: Do not argue that Buddhism disproves God; argue that it dispenses with God, since the printed stems ask whether religion is possible without God, not whether God has been refuted.

MCQ 7. The undeclared questions, used at their real scope

What is the correct examination use of the Buddha's undeclared questions (avyakata) in a religion-without-God answer?

- A. They show that the Buddha treated all religious language as meaningless, anticipating the verification principle by more than two millennia.
- B. They record the Buddha's own uncertainty, so Buddhism is best classified as a developed form of strong agnosticism about the divine.
- C. They concern particular speculative issues the path does not require, and must not be offered as the whole Buddhist case against a creator.
- D. They are a formal declaration that no divine being of any kind exists, which is why Buddhism is properly classified as an atheistic religion.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this smuggles in a semantic thesis owned by the Religious Language clause, whereas the undeclared questions concern profitability for the path rather than meaningfulness.
- **B:** Incorrect: the refusal is pedagogical and soteriological rather than a confession of ignorance, and importing the agnostic label blurs the four negative positions the clause asks you to separate.
- **C:** Correct: the owner restricts their scope deliberately, since setting certain metaphysical questions aside as unprofitable is a far narrower claim than a doctrinal denial that any divine being exists.
- **D:** Incorrect: silence about a question is not denial of its subject matter, and the atheistic label is exactly the imprecision this clause is designed to penalise in the opening paragraph.

Examiner trap 7: The poisoned-arrow parable illustrates the urgency of removing suffering, not the non-existence of gods; use it to explain why speculation is deferred, never as proof of atheism.

MCQ 8. Gods inside the cosmology, and devotional Mahayana

Which statement handles gods within Buddhism, and later devotional Mahayana, without conceding the theist's point?

- A. Devotional Mahayana shows that Buddhism became straightforwardly theistic, so only the earliest Buddhism can still count as evidence against creator-necessity.
- B. Because gods appear in the cosmology, Buddhism is covertly monotheistic and its non-theism is really a modern Western reconstruction of the living tradition.
- C. Buddhist teaching requires denial of every god, so any text that mentions them must be treated as a later devotional corruption of the original doctrine.
- D. Gods and Brahma figures remain impermanent beings inside rebirth, and Buddhas and bodhisattvas may carry devotional functions without becoming a creator.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: performing a religious function is not the same as occupying the creator role, so the concession is unnecessary and the counterexample survives the devotional development intact.
- **B:** Incorrect: a plurality of impermanent beings is not monotheism, and the reconstruction charge ignores the tradition's own doctrinal denial that any of those beings created or can finally save.
- **C:** Incorrect: the owner states plainly that Buddhism does not deny every deity, and the corruption move is a textual claim that none of the controlling sources here supports.
- **D:** Correct: this holds both lines at once, denying creatorhood and salvific ultimacy to the gods while conceding that being non-theistic does not make a tradition devotion-free.

Examiner trap 8: Examiners reward the sentence separating religious function from ontological status: devotion to a Buddha performs some of what worship performs without installing an omnipotent maker.

MCQ 9. What orients Buddhist religious life

Which formulation of what organises Buddhist religious life, in the absence of a creator, is the most defensible in an answer?

- A. Teaching, community and liberation organise doctrine, practice and value without working as one-for-one substitutes for a personal creator.
- B. Dharma occupies the place of God, the Sangha the place of the church and nirvana the place of heaven, so the two religious structures map onto each other one to one.
- C. Meditative attainment alone organises Buddhist life, since ethics and community are later cultural additions rather than constitutive parts of the path.
- D. The Four Noble Truths function as revealed propositions from an authority whose reliability has first to be accepted on faith before practice can begin.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the qualification does the work, because saying that these simply replace God invites the hidden-God objection that non-theistic religion is theism operating under other names.
- **B:** Incorrect: functional similarity does not establish ontological identity, and this neat mapping is exactly the concession that the hidden-God objection needs in order to succeed.
- **C:** Incorrect: moral discipline and the community are constitutive elements of the eightfold path and of its institutional form, not optional cultural accretions added afterwards.
- **D:** Incorrect: they are presented as a diagnosis to be tested in practice, and propositional revelation from a divine speaker is one of the functions this clause identifies as genuinely theistic.

Examiner trap 9: The examiner is watching for the phrase 'not a one-for-one substitute'; without it your own Buddhist paragraph hands the theist the reply he needs.

MCQ 10. The Jain case against a creator

Which pair of considerations captures the Jain argument against a creator God as the owner states it?

- A. Scripture is authorless and therefore needs no divine speaker, so the whole argument from the reliability of a speaker collapses at once.
- B. Only momentary events exist, so there is no persisting agent capable of performing a single sustained act of world-creation at any point whatever.
- C. The world is eternal and uncreated, and consciousness emerges from the body, so no soul survives that would require a maker to account for it.
- D. A perfect being has no unfulfilled motive that creating could satisfy, and an embodied creator would be limited by the embodiment that action requires.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is the Mimamsa route through the authorless Veda, which is a different counterexample resting on a different mechanism from the Jain motive and embodiment arguments.
- **B:** Incorrect: momentariness is a Buddhist thesis, while Jain metaphysics is explicitly substantialist about souls and matter and could not use this premise without abandoning its own ontology.
- **C:** Incorrect: the second half is Carvaka's materialist thesis, whereas Jainism affirms innumerable eternal souls and a genuine liberation, both of which materialism denies outright.
- **D:** Correct: motive and limitation are the two Jain pressures, and the same argument family reappears in Kumarila's attack on the possibility of a bodiless agent acting upon matter.

Examiner trap 10: Never describe the liberated Jain soul as a creator God under another name; it is an achieved perfection rather than a governing one, and that difference defeats the hidden-God objection.

MCQ 11. Authorless scripture is not revelation

Why must the Mimamsa Veda never be described in an answer as revelation?

- A. Because it was composed by human seers whose insight is treated as authoritative only within the boundaries of the ritual tradition.
- B. Because it is held to be authorless, so its authority does not depend on the reliability of any speaker, whether divine or human.
- C. Because revelation there is delivered through the deities named in the mantras, who dictate the injunctions to the priesthood.
- D. Because Mimamsa treats the Veda as literally false yet pragmatically useful for organising the ritual life of a community.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: human composition is exactly what the doctrine denies, since a composed text would inherit its author's fallibility and the school's whole case rests on avoiding that.
- **B:** Correct: revelation presupposes a revealer, and the Mimamsa claim is that eternal, unauthored injunction needs no speaker whose trustworthiness would first have to be established by some further argument.
- **C:** Incorrect: those deities function as elements within the ritual structure, the dative to which the oblation is offered, and are not agents who hear, choose, dictate or grant anything.
- **D:** Incorrect: this imports modern fictionalism into a school whose injunctions are held to be intrinsically valid, and intrinsic validity is incompatible with treating them as useful falsehoods.

Examiner trap 11: One careless sentence calling the Veda 'revealed' surrenders the whole Mimamsa counterexample, because revelation reinstates the divine speaker the school has just removed.

MCQ 12. How Mimamsa defines what it studies

Jaimini's Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2 defines dharma. Which reading of that definition is accurate and examinable?

- A. Dharma is what is characterised by Vedic injunction and is beneficial, so it is known from injunction alone and never from perception or inference.
- B. Dharma is the eternal moral law inscribed in the nature of things and therefore knowable by unaided human reason working from the observed order of things.
- C. Dharma is whatever produces the greatest welfare, so injunctions may be revised whenever their consequences turn out on inspection to be harmful in ordinary ritual practice.
- D. Dharma is the command of a supreme being, transmitted through the Veda and enforced by the fruits that are assigned to agents in a life after death.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the sutra reads *codana-laksano 'rtho dharmah*, and the epistemic consequence is the reason for citing it, since injunction is made the sole source of the knowledge of dharma.
- **B:** Incorrect: natural-law knowability is exactly what Mimamsa denies, because perception and inference are held to be incapable of reaching dharma at all, which is why injunction is required.
- **C:** Incorrect: this converts a scriptural criterion into a consequentialist one and loses the school's distinctive claim that injunction is epistemically prior to any assessment of outcomes.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is divine-command theory, and it reinstates both the divine speaker and the divine dispenser that classical Mimamsa argues at length are entirely unnecessary.

Examiner trap 12: If you cite the sutra, cite it for the epistemic point that dharma is knowable only from injunction; quoting it as decoration without that consequence earns no marks at all.

MCQ 13. The argument that generates apurva

Which reconstruction of the Mimamsa argument for the unseen potency (apurva) is correct in both its structure and its epistemic status?

- A. The promised fruit is purely psychological, consisting in the confidence the performer gains from having discharged the standing injunction properly and in order.
- B. Ritual acts are observed to generate a subtle physical residue in the performer, and that residue is then directly perceived by sufficiently advanced practitioners.
- C. A momentary act cannot produce a much later fruit, so a persisting potency is postulated to bridge them and admitted as a postulate, not as something observed.
- D. A supervising deity records each performance and assigns the promised fruit at the appropriate time, and the technical term simply names the record that is kept in this way.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the promised results are objective states of affairs in the school's own account, and a psychological reading dissolves the very problem that the postulate was introduced to solve.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing whatever is claimed to be perceived here, and treating the potency as an observed entity is a listed trap that misstates the school's own account of how it is known.
- **C:** Correct: the injunction promises a delayed result, the act perishes, a perished cause cannot produce a later effect, and the school's own epistemology licenses postulation to explain an otherwise inexplicable fact.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the Nyaya superintendent that the postulate exists to make unnecessary, so the reading inverts the argument and hands the theist back the function Mimamsa has removed.

Examiner trap 13: State all five steps or none; a bare assertion that ritual generates apurva, without the perished-cause problem, reads as vocabulary rather than as argument.

MCQ 14. Kumarila against Prabhakara

How do the two classical Mimamsa schools differ in their treatment of the injunction and its fruit?

- A. Kumarila accepts a creator God as the guarantor of ritual efficacy, whereas Prabhakara rejects any such divine guarantor of the system entirely.
- B. Kumarila treats the unseen potency as a power in the act or agent linking deed to fruit; Prabhakara recentres the analysis on the sheer ought-to-be- done.
- C. Kumarila regards ritual as symbolic self-expression, while Prabhakara regards the ritual act itself as genuinely and causally efficacious.
- D. Kumarila holds that the Veda has a divine author while Prabhakara holds that it is authorless, which is why only the second of the two schools genuinely avoids theism.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Kumarila's Slokavarttika contains sustained arguments against a creator, including the motive problem and the impossibility of a bodiless agent acting upon matter.
- **B:** Correct: the difference carries an ethical payoff, since Prabhakara's account is closer to a deontology of the injunction and Kumarila's to a consequential mechanism of desert.
- **C:** Incorrect: neither treats ritual as symbolic self-expression and the efficacy claim is shared, so the disagreement has to be located in what the injunction primarily discloses.
- **D:** Incorrect: authorlessness is common ground for classical Mimamsa, and the dispute between the two concerns the analysis of injunction and fruit rather than the origin of the text.

Examiner trap 14: Naming Kumarila and Prabhakara without stating the deontology-versus- desert consequence is name-dropping; the distinction earns marks only when the ethical payoff is spelt out.

MCQ 15. Answering Nyaya's superintendent argument

Nyaya objects that an unconscious potency cannot select the right fruit for the right agent at the right time. What is the Mimamsa reply?

- A. That the question of allocation is unanswerable and should be set aside in the manner of the questions the Buddha left formally undeclared.
- B. That fruits are allotted by liberated souls who have completed the ritual path and and who now supervise the operation of that path on behalf of others.
- C. That the relation is law-like rather than deliberative, and that the objection begs the question by assuming only agents can produce determinate outcomes.
- D. That the deities named in the mantras perform the selection, so an intelligent allocator is quietly retained within the ritual system after all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the undeclared questions belong to the Buddhist material, and Mimamsa offers a positive account of how act and fruit are connected rather than a refusal to answer.
- **B:** Incorrect: this borrows Jain vocabulary and installs a governing agency that both schools deny, since liberated beings on either account do not administer the world or its rewards.
- **C:** Correct: the exchange turns on whether determinate results require deliberation, and Mimamsa holds that regular natural law delivers determinate outcomes without any selecting mind supervising them.
- **D:** Incorrect: those deities are elements within the ritual structure rather than agents who hear, choose and grant, so this concedes precisely the objection it was supposed to answer.

Examiner trap 15: Do not answer Nyaya by attacking theism in general; answer the specific allocation argument, because that is where a fifteen-mark script separates itself from a ten-mark one.

MCQ 16. Samkhya, Yoga and the non-creating Isvara

Which statement handles classical Samkhya and Yoga correctly inside a religion-without-God answer?

- A. Both reduce liberation to the cessation of the material world itself, so the stated goal is cosmic dissolution rather than any individual release at all.
- B. Samkhya treats consciousness as a product of material evolution, which is why it needs no creator at all to explain the first arising of conscious awareness.
- C. Both systems posit a creator who superintends the evolution of nature, so neither of the two can serve as a genuine case of religion without God.
- D. Samkhya derives evolution from nature in proximity to plural selves and seeks isolation, while Yoga's special self is not straightforwardly a creator.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: isolation is the discriminative release of the self from entanglement with evolving nature, and it neither requires nor asserts the annihilation of nature as such.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is the materialist thesis, whereas Samkhya holds consciousness to be an irreducible principle wholly distinct from the evolving material order it illuminates.
- **C:** Incorrect: classical Samkhya is a standard non-theistic case in the owner, and even Yoga's Isvara is a special self rather than a maker or governor of the world process.
- **D:** Correct: keeping the two systems apart on this point prevents the common error of importing Yoga's Isvara into classical Samkhya and thereby destroying the counterexample being offered.

Examiner trap 16: The objection that unconscious principles cannot organise ends is answered by denying that observed regularity must be modelled on artefact production; the milk-and-calf analogy does exactly that work.

MCQ 17. The route the 2025 directive is buying

The 2025 question asks for Carvaka's critique of belief in suprasensible entities. Which route through the material does the directive actually buy?

- A. The linguistic route: terms for suprasensible entities fail a criterion of meaning, so claims that involve them turn out to be neither true nor false.
- B. The epistemological route: perception alone is a means of knowledge, and inference fails because invariable concomitance cannot itself be established.
- C. The historical route: the school documents that religious institutions arose to secure ritual income, which explains belief in unseen entities.
- D. The ethical route: since pleasure and wealth are the only real human ends, religious goods stand exposed as fabrications serving established priestly interests.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is verificationism, owned by the Religious Language clause, whereas Carvaka grants that the claims are meaningful and denies only that they can ever be known.
- **B:** Correct: the directive asks for the argument of the critique rather than its conclusions, so the analysis of the means of knowledge, not the hedonist slogans, is what the examiner is paying for.
- **C:** Incorrect: a sociological genealogy is not what the reported Carvaka argument offers, and the surviving verses are doxographic quotations rather than historical evidence of any kind.
- **D:** Incorrect: the reduction of human ends is a consequence of the epistemology, so an answer built on hedonism misses the printed demand for the argument of the critique itself.

Examiner trap 17: The hedonist couplet and the verses attributed to Brhaspati survive only in opponents' doxographies, chiefly Madhava's Sarvadarsanasamgraha; report them as such, and never build the answer on them.

MCQ 18. The concomitance problem, stated in full

Which statement gives the Carvaka attack on inference completely, including the residue that survives however often the concomitance is observed?

- A. Concomitance is known by repeated observation, but observation is unreliable because the senses are frequently deceived by illusion, by dream and by defect.
- B. Inference is valid for the supersensible but invalid for ordinary matters, since everyday judgements are contaminated by practical interest.
- C. Inference is invalid because the mark and the inferred object are never once present together within any one single and complete act of perception.
- D. Concomitance is unreachable by perception, by inference and by testimony, and an unnoticed conditioning factor can never be conclusively excluded.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the parity argument used by critics against Carvaka rather than the Carvaka case, and it concedes at the outset that concomitance can in fact be known.
- **B:** Incorrect: this exactly reverses the reported Purandara position, which admits ordinary inference while denying it for what lies beyond the reach of the senses altogether.
- **C:** Incorrect: co-presence in particular cases is exactly what the argument grants; the difficulty lies in the leap from observed particulars to an unrestricted universal covering unobserved cases.
- **D:** Correct: the three closed routes plus the conditioning-factor residue constitute the whole argument, and it is the residue that reduces inference from certainty to mere probability.

Examiner trap 18: An answer saying only that 'Carvaka rejects inference', without the concomitance analysis and the conditioning-factor residue, has stated a conclusion and omitted the argument the directive demanded.

MCQ 19. Self-refutation, and the two replies that are required

The claim that no inference is valid looks self-refuting. Which pair of replies does the owner require an answer to supply?

- A. The appeal to scriptural silence, since no accepted text asserts the validity of inference anywhere in so many words, or in any equivalent formula.
- B. The appeal to practical success, since the school's followers manifestly survive and prosper in daily life while relying upon perception alone.
- C. The dialectical reading, on which the denial is pressed from inside the opponent's own commitments, and the reported strand admitting ordinary inference only.
- D. The appeal to Nyaya's devices, since repeated uncontradicted observation and hypothetical reasoning are conceded by both parties to the dispute.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Carvaka rejects scriptural authority outright, so an argument resting on what scripture does or does not assert is simply unavailable to the school in the first place.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the pragmatic argument used against Carvaka, because no one, including a Carvaka, can eat, speak, teach or argue without relying on inference constantly.
- **C:** Correct: these are the two moves that rescue the school from a self-defeating universal claim, and the second yields the far more defensible thesis about the limits of inference.
- **D:** Incorrect: those are Nyaya's positive defence of concomitance and are precisely what Carvaka contests, so they cannot be pressed into service as a Carvaka reply at all.

Examiner trap 19: Leaving the self-refutation charge unanswered forfeits the evaluation marks; give the dialectical reading and the reported moderate strand, and flag that the evidence for the latter is fragmentary.

MCQ 20. Consciousness, order and the four elements

Which set of Carvaka applications to religion is correctly matched to the device that supports it?

- A. Consciousness emerges from the body, illustrated by intoxicating power arising from combined ingredients, and order follows from things acting by their own nature.
- B. Consciousness is a mode of one single substance, nature, and order follows from the necessity with which that single substance's own attributes unfold.
- C. Consciousness is a stream of momentary events, and order is explained by dependent conditioning that holds among those very momentary events themselves.
- D. Consciousness is an eternal substance temporarily housed in the body, and cosmic order is explained by the slow and gradual ripening of deeds performed in past lives.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: emergence removes survival, transmigration and liberation together, while the own-nature explanation removes any need for a designer of the thorn's sharpness or the peacock's colour.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is Spinoza's apparatus, which the owner names as the historical ancestor of religious naturalism rather than as anything belonging to Carvaka materialism.
- **C:** Incorrect: momentariness and dependent conditioning are Buddhist doctrines, and Buddhism retains exactly the supersensible order that Carvaka's epistemology closes off completely.
- **D:** Incorrect: both halves are exactly what Carvaka denies, since an eternal conscious substance and karmic ripening are among the supersensible postulates directly under attack.

Examiner trap 20: The four gross elements exhaust reality on this view and ether is rejected as imperceptible; getting that list wrong signals that the epistemology behind it has not been understood.

MCQ 21. Why Carvaka is the limiting case

Why is it a mark-earning move to deny that Carvaka is itself an instance of religion without God?

- A. Because its texts survive only in the works of opponents, and a tradition without its own surviving scripture cannot properly be counted as a religion.
- B. Because it denies rebirth, and any system without rebirth falls outside the recognised Indian category of religion altogether and at once.
- C. Because it is a school of philosophy rather than a tradition, and philosophy is never counted as religion within the classical Indian doxographic context.
- D. Because it has no soteriology, sacred order, community of practice or ultimate concern, and so shows what non-theistic religions actually retain.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the transmission problem is a source-discipline point governing how the verses may be quoted, and it is not a criterion of religious status at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: rebirth is not the criterion in play here, and adopting it would wrongly expel non-Indian non-theistic positions by applying a purely local test to them.
- **C:** Incorrect: Samkhya and Mimamsa are also philosophical schools yet function as religious systems in this clause, so the philosophy label does not settle the classification question.
- **D:** Correct: the contrast is the point, since Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa survive the loss of God while Carvaka closes the epistemic route to any supersensible object and ends in no religion at all.

Examiner trap 21: The verdict formula is that the critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does: the strong thesis is self-refuting and unliveable, the moderate thesis is unrefuted and fatal to inference-based natural theology.

MCQ 22. Nietzsche's diagnosis, and who owns the question

Which handling of Nietzsche is correct both philosophically and in terms of syllabus ownership?

- A. It is a historical report of declining church attendance in nineteenth-century Europe, and it therefore belongs to sociology rather than to philosophy proper.
- B. It is a theological thesis about divine self-emptying, so Nietzsche's target turns out to be only one particular Christian doctrine of God among many.
- C. It is a cultural diagnosis of a collapsed value horizon, and the printed question coupling religion with morality belongs to the Religion and Morality owner.
- D. It is a compressed argument for atheism, establishing by inference from the problem of evil that no deity of the traditional theistic kind exists at all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reducing the declaration to an empirical event is a listed trap, since the claim concerns the unbelievability of an entire framework rather than attendance statistics.
- **B:** Incorrect: no source in this clause supports that reading, and it dissolves a cultural diagnosis into a theological doctrine that Nietzsche is certainly not defending.
- **C:** Correct: this clause keeps Nietzsche as a critique of theistic religion and as the bridge to post-theistic value, while the full genealogical dossier is routed to the neighbouring owner file.
- **D:** Incorrect: it is not an existence proof at all, and attaching it to the problem of evil confuses two separate clauses with two quite different owners and demands.

Examiner trap 22: Nietzsche mourns a horizon that Buddhism and Jainism never possessed; using him as a general spokesman for religion without God confuses post-theism with non-theism.

MCQ 23. Dewey and Dworkin on religion within nature

Which pairing of thinker and thesis in religious naturalism is accurate as the owner states it?

- A. Dewey separates religion as institution from the religious as a unifying quality of experience; Dworkin rests religious atheism on value and cosmic sublimity.
- B. Dewey argues that religious language is non-assertoric make-believe, while Dworkin defends a personal God stripped of the attribute of omnipotence.
- C. Dewey identifies God with the natural universe taken as a single substance, while Dworkin identifies God with humanity's own idealised and projected essence.
- D. Both hold that religious naturalism requires abandoning ritual and community, since both of these are held to be inseparable from supernatural belief.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Dewey proposes using the word God for the active relation between the ideal and the actual, and Dworkin makes value realism rather than theism the core of what is religious about religion.
- **B:** Incorrect: non-assertoric participation is fictionalism rather than naturalism, and Dworkin's position is explicitly atheistic about any personal God whatever.
- **C:** Incorrect: the first formula is Spinoza's and the second is Feuerbach's projection thesis, so neither belongs to the thinker to whom it has here been attached.
- **D:** Incorrect: naturalists defend themselves precisely by pointing to reverence, communal practice and self-transformation as the religious elements that survive the loss of supernatural ontology.

Examiner trap 23: The objection that this is ethics and aesthetics in religious vocabulary is met by naming ultimacy, reverence, community and transformation, and by noting that demanding a supernatural person merely restates theism.

MCQ 24. Fictionalism, error theory and non-cognitivism

Which set of distinctions among the modern non-theistic positions is correct?

- A. All three are versions of religious naturalism, differing only in how much reverence each of them recommends towards the natural world as it stands.
- B. Error theory calls the claims false and abandons them, non-cognitivism denies they have truth-conditions, and fictionalism grants these and declines to assert.
- C. Non-cognitivism and fictionalism agree that religious sentences lack truth-conditions and differ only over which of the inherited rituals ought to be retained.
- D. Fictionalism and error theory agree that the claims are false and differ only over whether that falsity ought in honesty to be publicised to ordinary worshippers.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: naturalism asserts its claims about ultimacy within nature and therefore stands apart from all three, and merging the four is expressly listed among the clause's traps.
- **B:** Correct: fictionalism is defined by the refusal to assert rather than by a verdict on meaning or by abandonment of the practice, which is why it stands as a genuinely distinct third position.
- **C:** Incorrect: the fictionalist grants that religious sentences have truth-conditions, which is the entire point of declining to assert them rather than denying that they mean anything.
- **D:** Incorrect: the difference has nothing to do with publicity and everything to do with whether the practice is abandoned or accepted and continued in a non-assertoric spirit.

Examiner trap 24: Advaita's everyday level is not fictionalism: sublation is not falsification, and the two-level device preserves the practitioner's sincerity in a way explicit make-believe cannot.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

MCQ 25. Remedial - "Buddhism is an atheistic religion"

Which correction is best?

- A. It is atheistic in the strict sense, since the undeclared questions amount to a formal doctrinal denial that any divine being whatever exists at all.
- B. It is agnostic rather than atheistic, since the Buddha suspended judgement on a creator for want of sufficient evidence pointing decisively in either direction.
- C. It is better described as non-theistic, since a creator is absent from the diagnosis and path while impermanent gods and devotional practice are not denied.
- D. It is theistic in its later forms, so no single label applies and the classification question should simply be left open for each separate school.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: silence about a set of speculative questions is not denial of their subject matter, and the undeclared questions have a deliberately restricted scope.
- **B:** Incorrect: agnosticism is an epistemic verdict about evidence, whereas the Buddhist point is that the creator question is idle for the therapeutic path being prescribed.
- **C:** Correct: it repairs the label and states what the label leaves standing, which is exactly what the owner's firewall between non-theism and atheism requires of a script.
- **D:** Incorrect: devotional development does not install an omnipotent creator, and refusing any label evades the very discrimination the examiner is testing in this clause.

Examiner trap 25: Correcting the label without saying what non-theism permits leaves half the error standing; name the impermanent gods and the devotional practice in the same sentence.

MCQ 26. Remedial - "Carvaka is the clearest religion without God"

Which correction is best?

- A. It cannot be classified either way, because its own texts survive only inside the summaries written by its philosophical opponents.
- B. It is the limiting case, not an instance, since it lacks soteriology, sacred order, community of practice and ultimate concern, and ends in no religion at all.
- C. It is an instance, since rejecting God is the only condition that a religion without God has to satisfy before it can qualify in the first place.
- D. It is an instance, because its this-worldly ends function as a soteriology aimed at securing ordinary human flourishing within the limits of the present life.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the transmission problem constrains how the verses may be quoted rather than whether the doctrines can be classified, and the reported positions are determinate enough.
- **B:** Correct: it converts a misclassification into the contrast that shows what the non-theistic religions actually retain once a creator has been given up.
- **C:** Incorrect: this makes the absence of one belief sufficient for membership and silently abandons every positive criterion of religion the clause has been building.
- **D:** Incorrect: pleasure and wealth in this life are not a diagnosis of a fundamental predicament together with a disciplined path leading out of it, which is what soteriology means.

Examiner trap 26: The reward here is the sentence that religion can survive the loss of God but not the loss of a sacred order; write it explicitly rather than leaving it implied.

MCQ 27. Remedial - "the Mimamsa Veda is divine revelation"

Which correction is best?

- A. The Veda is authorless and therefore not the speech of any God, which is why arguments from the reliability of a divine speaker get no purchase on it.
- B. It is revelation given to the seers, whose authority the school then treats as intrinsically valid and therefore immune from any further external challenge.
- C. It is a human composition whose authority rests on long communal acceptance rather than on the personal standing of any one particular speaker or author.
- D. It is revelation, but of an impersonal rather than a personal deity, so the school remains theistic in at least a weak, indirect and heavily attenuated sense.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: it names the doctrine, draws the consequence and shows exactly why the counterexample to creator-necessity survives the objection being pressed.
- **B:** Incorrect: intrinsic validity attaches to the injunction itself and not to the reliability of any recipient, transmitter or inspired individual seer.
- **C:** Incorrect: human composition is denied as firmly as divine authorship, because a composed text would inherit the fallibility of whoever composed it.
- **D:** Incorrect: an impersonal revealer is still a revealer, whereas the doctrine denies that there is any author whatsoever standing behind the text.

Examiner trap 27: Watch your own vocabulary: 'revealed', 'scripture given by God' and 'divine word' all silently reinstate the speaker the school has just removed.

MCQ 28. Remedial - "apurva is an unseen force we observe in ritual"

Which correction is best?

- A. It is directly perceived by the officiating priest, which is why only properly qualified performers are permitted to conduct the rite on another's behalf.
- B. It is a postulate introduced to explain a delayed fruit, and the two schools differ over whether it is a power in the act or the sheer ought-to-be-done.
- C. It is a metaphor for the psychological confidence produced by having properly discharged a standing duty, and it therefore carries no ontological weight at all.
- D. It is inferred from repeated observation of ritual outcomes, in the same way that the presence of fire is regularly inferred from the observation of rising smoke.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: nothing is perceived on this account, and the qualification rules concern ritual competence rather than any privileged perceptual access to a potency.
- **B:** Correct: it corrects the epistemic status and adds the Kumarila-Prabhakara discrimination that a strong script carries into the objection-and-reply stage.
- **C:** Incorrect: it is introduced precisely to do ontological work, bridging a perished act and a much later fruit, so a metaphorical reading dissolves the problem it answers.
- **D:** Incorrect: the promised results typically mature long after the act and often after death, so the observational base such an inference would require simply does not exist.

Examiner trap 28: A postulate explaining an otherwise inexplicable fact is a licensed move in this school's own epistemology; say so, or the charge of arbitrary invention goes unanswered.

MCQ 29. Remedial - "Nietzsche proved that God does not exist"

Which correction is best?

- A. It is a proof, though an inductive rather than a deductive one, resting on the observed historical failure of the great religious institutions.
- B. It is a report that the deity of Christianity once existed in fact and has at some later point in European history ceased to exist altogether.
- C. It is a claim that the word 'God' is meaningless, so that the question of existence never actually arises for serious philosophical discussion.
- D. The declaration diagnoses that belief has become unbelievable and that dependent values now face nihilism; it is not a demonstration of non- existence.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: recasting a cultural diagnosis as an induction still treats it as an argument about existence, which is exactly the misreading being corrected.
- **B:** Incorrect: reading the declaration as an empirical event is a listed trap and makes nonsense of the genealogical project it introduces in Nietzsche's own writing.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is a semantic thesis owned by another clause entirely, whereas Nietzsche's concern is the collapse of a framework of values and what follows from it.
- **D:** Correct: it identifies the kind of claim being made and names its consequence, which is the demand for revaluation rather than any inference to a metaphysical conclusion.

Examiner trap 29: Follow the diagnosis with its consequence: inherited values depended on the framework, its collapse threatens nihilism, and overcoming it requires revaluation and self-creation.

MCQ 30. Remedial - "agnosticism is a hesitant form of atheism"

Which correction is best?

- A. Agnosticism holds that religious statements are neither true nor false, so belief and disbelief turn out to be equally confused responses to them.
- B. Agnosticism denies God's existence but withholds public assertion of that denial for broadly social, professional and prudential reasons of an entirely personal kind.
- C. Agnosticism suspends judgement rather than denying, and subdivides into the weak claim that the matter is not known and the strong claim that it is unknowable.
- D. Agnosticism is indifference to religious questions and therefore has no bearing on the separate question of whether religion without God is possible.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is non-cognitivism about religious language, which is a claim about meaning rather than a claim about what can or cannot be known.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is atheism with a communication strategy attached, and it erases the epistemic content that makes agnosticism a distinct position at all.
- **C:** Correct: it separates suspension from denial and supplies the weak-strong subdivision that the printed question expects an answer to provide.
- **D:** Incorrect: indifference is a fourth position, and agnostics may value religion's ethical and experiential dimensions while still withholding assent on the existence of God.

Examiner trap 30: Kant's practical faith and Spencer's Unknowable are agnostic-adjacent and show that suspending theoretical judgement is compatible with a continuing religious life.

MCQ 31. Remedial - "dharma and nirvana are God under other names"

Which correction is best?

- A. The objection fails because every religion, theistic or not, ultimately refers to one and the same finally indeterminate ultimate reality.
- B. The objection is correct, and non-theistic religions are therefore covert theisms that have simply changed their working vocabulary over the intervening centuries.
- C. The objection fails because dharma and nirvana perform no religious functions whatever, being purely philosophical categories of a technical kind.
- D. Functional replacement does not establish ontological identity: impersonal law is not an omniscient person, and liberation by insight is not grace bestowed.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is a pluralist thesis owned by another clause, and it answers a quite different question from the one the hidden-God objection actually raises.
- **B:** Incorrect: this concedes an inference from similar role to identical entity, which is exactly the step the owner rejects when it answers the hidden-God objection.
- **C:** Incorrect: they plainly do organise doctrine, practice and value, and denying that would abandon the very case for calling these traditions religions in the first place.
- **D:** Correct: it names the fallacy inside the hidden-God objection and supplies the two discriminations that are needed to defeat it in a single sentence.

Examiner trap 31: Do not let your own exposition invite this objection: avoid saying that dharma 'takes the place of' God, and state instead what work it does and does not do.

MCQ 32. Remedial - "naturalism and fictionalism are one position"

Which correction is best?

- A. The naturalist asserts that ultimacy and reverence lie within nature; the fictionalist declines to assert the claims and participates non-assertorically.
- B. Both are versions of the two-level Indian device, and differ only over which of the two levels ought in the end to be described as the ultimate one.
- C. Both accept that religious claims are false, and differ only over whether ritual practice should nevertheless be retained by the community afterwards.
- D. Both hold that religious language lacks truth-conditions, and differ only over the role that a community ought to play in a continuing religious life.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: assertion is the dividing line, and stating it also keeps error theory, which abandons the discourse altogether, separate from both of the other positions.
- **B:** Incorrect: the Indian device sublates rather than falsifies, which is precisely why it preserves the practitioner's sincerity in a way that fictionalism struggles to do.
- **C:** Incorrect: the naturalist asserts claims she takes to be true about value and about nature, so the shared-falsity premise is mistaken from the very beginning.
- **D:** Incorrect: the missing-truth-conditions thesis is non-cognitivism, and neither religious naturalism nor religious fictionalism is defined by holding it.

Examiner trap 32: The comparative sentence worth writing is that Indian systems offer graded truth where Western fictionalism offers pretence, which is why sincerity is easier to preserve on the Indian model.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified previous-year questions - 7 complete solutions

Word bands used throughout. 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its **exact printed wording** from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025, in which this clause owns seven question-parts and is absent as a primary owner only in 2022.

The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

Timing skeleton. 10 marks - 1 minute to decode, 1 to outline, 6 to write, 1 to check. 15 marks - 1 / 2 / 10 / 2. 20 marks - 2 / 3 / 13 / 2. **Standing penalties in this clause:** an answer with no stated definition of religion; "atheistic" used where "non-theistic" is meant; Cārvāka offered as an instance rather than as the limit; the Mīmāṃsā Veda called revelation; and any invented year for Smart, Feuerbach, Freud or Comte.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q5(c), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can you justify religion without God? Support your answer.

Demand decoding: "Justify" requires a defended position with the criterion stated, not a catalogue of godless schools. Announce the definition of religion first; the whole answer follows from it.

Model solution: Yes - provided religion is defined not substantively, by the kind of object affirmed, but multidimensionally. Ninian Smart's dimensions are doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material; belief in a creator is not among them.

Buddhism satisfies every dimension. Dependent origination and karma explain conditioned arising; the Four Noble Truths diagnose; the Eightfold Path disciplines; the *Śaṅgha* sustains; *nirvāṇa* completes. Jainism rejects a creator on the motive and embodiment arguments while retaining vows and the perfected *siddha*. Mīmāṃsā is sharper still: the Veda is authorless (*apauruṣeya*), so no divine speaker is required, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) links act to delayed fruit without a divine dispenser.

The justification must be bounded. A definition broad enough to admit any strong commitment is empty, so the sacred-order and soteriological conditions are added - which is exactly why Cārvāka, having closed the route to every supersensible object, is the limiting case rather than an instance.

Religion without God is therefore justified; religion without a sacred order is not.

Why this earns marks:

- Opens with a defended criterion instead of a list of schools.
- Uses three Indian traditions with their distinct mechanisms, not their names.
- Polices the over-breadth of its own definition inside the answer.
- Classifies Cārvāka correctly as the limit, which is the clause's signature discrimination.
- Closes with a decided verdict in the exact form the directive requested.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: How would a religious person deny the possibility of a religion without God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: The stem asks you to argue the theist's case first, sympathetically and in its strongest form, and only then assess it. Half the marks are in the construction.

Model solution: A religious theist would deny the possibility on five grounds. **Definitional:** religion is a living relation between finite persons and a personal transcendent, so "religion without God" is a category error rather than an unusual species. **Devotional:** worship requires a recipient; praise, petition and surrender are relational acts, and Jain veneration of a passionless perfected being would then be commemoration rather than worship. **Moral:** unconditional obligation requires a commander whose will binds. **Cosmic-order:** purposive order and the exact allotment of karmic fruit require intelligence, which is why Nyāya posits *Īśvara* as creator and superintendent of karma (*karmādhyaṅśa*). **Soteriological:** forgiveness, grace and covenant require a responsive agent who can bestow them.

The denial nevertheless assumes its conclusion at the first step. Smart's dimensions show that doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience, narrative and community exist without a creator. Buddhism supplies a complete diagnosis of suffering, dependent origination, the path, the *Śaṅgha* and *nirvāṇa*. Mīmāṃsā answers the third and fourth arguments directly: the authorless Veda secures authority without a speaker, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) secures desert without a dispenser, the relation being law-like rather than deliberative. Jainism's *siddha* is an achieved, not a governing, divinity.

The theist may reply that *Dharma*, *nirvāṇa* and *apūrva* are hidden substitutes; but functional similarity does not establish ontological identity. The strongest surviving point is therefore devotional, not definitional: petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God, and non-theistic religions do without them at a real cost in devotional structure.

Religion without God is possible; religion without a sacred order is not.

Why this earns marks:

- Obeys the unusual directive by giving the theist's five arguments priority and philosophical force.
- Names Nyāya's superintendent of karma and then answers it with the correct Mīmāṃsā mechanism.
- Distinguishes achieved from governing divinity in the Jain case.
- Refuses the hidden-God inference explicitly rather than ignoring it.
- Concedes the devotional cost, which is what a graded verdict requires.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Critically examine the concept of God as prerequisite for a religion.

Demand decoding: "Prerequisite" is a necessity claim. Give the substantive definition its strongest defence, produce counterinstances, then state the limited functions for which a personal God really is indispensable.

Model solution: To call God a prerequisite is to claim that nothing counts as religion unless it includes belief in a divine being, usually a personal creator, moral governor and saviour.

The claim has genuine force. A substantive definition captures prayer, worship, revelation, covenant and grace precisely, and it guards against an over-broad functionalism under which nationalism or ideology becomes a religion merely by supplying meaning and community. The theist adds that worship requires one who is worshipped, unconditional obligation a supreme commander, and karmic order an intelligent administrator.

A prerequisite is nevertheless a necessary condition, and established traditions defeat it. Buddhism has doctrine, ethical discipline, meditation, monastic community and liberation without a creator; where gods occur they are impermanent beings within rebirth, neither makers nor indispensable saviours. Jainism rejects creation while affirming eternal souls, karmic matter, vows and the perfected *siddha*. Mīmāṃsā is the sharpest counterexample: dharma is known only from injunction - Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 - the Veda is authorless rather than revealed, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) explains the delayed fruit without a dispenser. Classical Sāṃkhya derives evolution from nature in proximity to plural selves and seeks isolation (*kaivalya*); Yoga's *Īśvara* is a special self and must not be read back into Sāṃkhya.

Modern positions extend the case while complicating it: Dewey's "the religious", Dworkin's religious atheism and religious fictionalism all detach religious functions from theistic belief, though critics reasonably ask whether what survives is religion or only spirituality.

God is therefore indispensable for petition, covenant, propositional revelation and grace - but not for religion as such. The concept of God is one powerful way of integrating religious functions, not their universal prerequisite.

Why this earns marks:

- Treats "prerequisite" as a necessity claim rather than describing non-theism generally.
- Defends the substantive definition before dismantling it.
- Uses four Indian counterexamples with doctrine-specific mechanisms, and protects the Sāṃkhya-Yoga distinction.
- Integrates the modern positions without equating them with classical soteriology.
- Ends with a bounded, function-by-function necessity verdict.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is religious life possible without the belief in God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: A possibility claim is established by one actual case done in depth, not by four cases mentioned. "Religious life" shifts the emphasis from doctrine to lived practice.

Model solution: It is possible, and the proof is actual rather than hypothetical.

Religious life consists in disciplined orientation to a sacred order, ritual and ethical formation, community and a transformative goal. Buddhism supplies all four without a creator: the Four Noble Truths diagnose the predicament, the Eightfold Path prescribes conduct, meditation and understanding, moral discipline (*śīla*) shapes daily action, the *Śaṅgha* transmits and sustains, and *nirvāṇa* is the goal. Where gods appear they are impermanent beings within rebirth, not saviours.

Mīmāṃsā shows the same for a ritual rather than a meditative life: injunction defines duty, and unseen potency (*apūrva*) connects the act to its fruit without a divine dispenser. Jain vows and asceticism organise a whole life around release.

Two limits should be conceded. Petition and grace do require a responsive God, so the personal texture of non-theistic religious life is different and arguably thinner. And religious life is not possible where every supersensible order has been closed off - which is why Cārvāka has an ethic but no religious life.

Belief in God is therefore sufficient for religious life in many traditions, but not necessary for it.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers the possibility question with one tradition treated in depth.
- Reads "religious life" as practice and answers on that register.
- Adds a second and third case briefly to show the result is not idiosyncratic.
- Concedes the devotional limit instead of overclaiming.
- Uses the Cārvāka boundary to show what "religious life" positively requires.

PYQ 5 - 2023, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question: What is Agnosticism? How do agnostics conceptualize the relation between religion and God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Two printed deliverables - a definition and a positional account. Define, sub-divide into weak and strong, then give the relation. Answering only the first half forfeits half the marks.

Model solution: Agnosticism is the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable, so that judgement should be suspended. The word was coined by T. H. Huxley in 1869. It is distinct from atheism, which denies God, and from indifference, which does not raise the question. **Weak agnosticism** holds that the matter is not known and remains open to evidence; **strong agnosticism** holds that it is unknowable in principle, which is itself a substantial epistemological thesis. Kant's practical faith and Spencer's "Unknowable" are adjacent positions.

On the relation between religion and God, agnostics treat the two as separable. Religious commitment can be graded, and need not include metaphysical certainty. An agnostic may therefore affirm religion's ethical dimension, its experiential and contemplative dimension, and its ritual and communal life, while withholding assent on the existence of God - a minimal or non-theistic religiosity. A person may, for instance, participate fully in Buddhist ethical and meditative practice while withholding creator claims.

The objection is that this reduces religion to ethics or aesthetics. The reply is that community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy exceed ordinary morality - although what remains is admittedly thinner than a fully theistic religious life.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers both printed deliverables, in the printed order, with a visible transition.
- Dates the coinage correctly and distinguishes agnosticism from atheism and indifference.
- Sub-divides into weak and strong and notes the cost of the strong form.
- States the presupposition - graded commitment - instead of assuming it.

- Meets the reduction objection and concedes what it should.

PYQ 6 - 2024, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.

Demand decoding: Two halves. State the doctrine fully before assessing it; do not evaluate a caricature. The evaluation must include the devotional complication and a graded verdict.

Model solution: Statement. Buddhism is non-theistic rather than atheistic: a creator is absent from its diagnosis and its path, though impermanent gods and later devotional practice are not denied. Dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) and karma explain conditioned arising; gods and *Brahmā* figures remain beings inside rebirth rather than creators or final saviours, as the *Brahmajāla* (DN 1) and *Aggañña* (DN 27) Suttas indicate. The Buddha's undeclared questions (*avyākata*) concern specific speculative issues that the path does not require, and must not be presented as the whole case.

What remains is a complete religion on a multidimensional definition. Doctrine: the Four Noble Truths, impermanence and non-self. Practice: the Noble Eightfold Path, meditation and monastic observance. Ethics: moral discipline (*śīla*). Community: the *Saṅgha*, with rule, ordination and transmission. Goal: *nirvāṇa*, liberation from suffering. Sacred order: *Dharma*, the order the path discloses. Teaching, community and liberation organise all of this without functioning as one-for-one substitutes for a personal creator.

Evaluation. The argument is one of redundancy, not refutation: a creator adds no explanatory or practical step to the causal-soteriological sequence. Its presupposition - that dependent causation suffices for the problem Buddhism addresses - is where a theist should press.

Three objections deserve answers. That karma is providence renamed: causal-moral regularity is impersonal, with nothing that selects, forgives or answers. That devotional Mahāyāna makes Buddhism theistic: Buddhas and bodhisattvas may perform religious functions without becoming an omnipotent creator, which shows that non-theistic does not mean devotion-free. That *Dharma* is God renamed: functional similarity does not establish ontological identity.

The cost must be conceded. Petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God, and Buddhism does without them; its devotional structure is therefore differently shaped.

Verdict. Buddhism is a strong actual counterexample to the claim that a personal creator is necessary - provided religion is defined multidimensionally rather than stipulated as God-relation, in which case the counterexample would have been excluded before it was examined.

Why this earns marks:

- Completes the statement before beginning the evaluation, as the directive demands.
- Runs the multidimensional cluster explicitly, element by element.
- Restricts the undeclared questions to their real scope and cites the text anchors.
- Answers the three standing objections rather than the easiest one.
- Concedes the devotional cost and closes with a conditional, graded verdict.

PYQ 7 - 2025, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss Cārvāka's critique of the belief in the existence of suprasensible entities.

Demand decoding: The directive buys the **argument** of the critique, not its conclusions. Give the epistemology - the concomitance problem - not the hedonist slogans.

Model solution: The critique is epistemological. Cārvāka holds that perception (*pratyakṣa*) alone is a means of knowledge, because a means of knowledge must yield certainty and every other candidate depends on a general rule that perception cannot certify.

The argument turns on inference. Inference depends on invariable, unconditional concomitance (*vyāpti*) between mark and inferred. How is that concomitance known? Not by perception, which grasps only particular co-presences while concomitance is universal. Not by inference, which would need its own concomitance, generating regress or circularity. Not by testimony, which is not a means of knowledge at all here. And even repeated observation cannot exclude an unnoticed conditioning factor (*upādhi*) - fire is accompanied by smoke only when the fuel is wet - so deviation remains possible and the concomitance remains merely probable.

Applied to religion: God is never perceived; consciousness is emergent from the body (*dehātmavāda*), illustrated by the intoxicating power arising from combined ingredients; karma and unseen merit are imperceptible postulates; order needs no maker, since things act by their own nature (*svabhāva-vāda*).

Two replies are required. The charge of self-refutation is met by reading the denial dialectically, and by the reported Purandara strand admitting ordinary inference while denying it for what lies beyond the senses. On that moderate reading the critique is unrefuted and fatal to every inference-based natural theology.

Why this earns marks:

- Gives the argument rather than the conclusions, as the directive requires.
- States all four moves of the concomitance problem, including the conditioning-factor residue.
- Applies the epistemology to the specific religious postulates.
- Supplies both replies to self-refutation and flags the reported strand as reported.
- Ends with the verdict formula tying the critique's success to its epistemology.

Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

The following are original, independently prepared practice questions and model answers, not previous-year questions or official solutions.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "Non-theistic is not identical with atheistic." Examine the significance of this distinction for the possibility of religion without God.

Model solution: The distinction decides the clause. Atheism denies that God exists; non-theism reports that a creator is absent from a tradition's diagnosis and path. The first is a claim about what exists, the second about what a path requires.

Its significance is that non-theism leaves standing everything a religion needs. Theravāda Buddhism permits cosmological gods while denying their creatorhood and salvific ultimacy; later Mahāyāna develops full devotion to Buddhas and bodhisattvas; Jainism venerates the perfected *siddha*. None of that would be available to a tradition committed to denying every deity and every sacred being.

The distinction also redistributes the burden of proof. The non-theist need only show that a complete religious structure exists without a creator, which is a claim about actual traditions. The atheist must additionally defend a universal negative.

The objection is that a creator assigned no role has effectively been denied. The reply is doctrinal: what Buddhism denies is creatorhood and final salvific power, not existence, and the surviving devotional practice is evidence that the narrower denial is the real one.

Loose use of "atheistic" therefore concedes the theist's framing in the first line and makes a strong case sound like a weak one.

Why this earns marks: States the distinction precisely; shows what it preserves; identifies the shift in burden of proof; answers the collapse objection with doctrinal evidence; ends with the examination consequence.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why classical Mīmāṃsā is often regarded as the sharpest counterexample to the claim that religion requires God.

Model solution: Because it removes God from a tradition that keeps everything else religion is usually thought to need: scripture, ritual, duty, merit and a promised fruit.

Three functions a deity normally performs are reassigned. Authority: the Veda is authorless (*apauruṣeya*), so no speaker's reliability needs establishing, and the theistic arguments from the text's status lose their premise. Duty: Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 defines dharma as what is characterised by injunction and is beneficial, so dharma is known from injunction alone, not from any deity's command. Desert: unseen potency (*apūrva*) is postulated to connect a perished momentary act with a much later fruit, answering the Nyāya demand for a superintendent of karma.

The deities named in the mantras are elements within the ritual structure - the dative of the offering - rather than agents who hear and grant.

Two qualifications are owed. Nyāya objects that an unconscious potency cannot select the right fruit for the right agent; Mīmāṃsā replies that the relation is law-like rather than deliberative, which the objector must then argue against. And later authors of the school drift toward theism, so the atheistic reading is of the classical system.

Mīmāṃsā thus shows that the functions God performs are separable, which is a stronger result than any single tradition's silence about a creator.

Why this earns marks: Identifies the three reassigned functions; quotes the sūtra for its epistemic consequence; states the postulate's status correctly; answers Nyāya; restricts the claim to the classical system.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "Functional definitions of religion purchase the possibility of religion without God at the price of admitting anything." Critically discuss.

Model solution: The charge is serious and half true, and the correct answer concedes the half before repairing it.

It is true that every functional feature over-generates on its own. Ultimate concern is a strong candidate but nations, art and political causes can become ultimate concerns. Ritual is widespread but secular ceremonies have it. Ethical orientation is common but ethical philosophies are not religions. Community is common but so are clubs. A definition assembled from these alone would indeed admit almost anything with sufficient intensity.

It is false that this is the only functional definition available. The working repair is a **cluster with two load-bearing conditions**: a disciplined and socially embodied relation to an ultimate or sacred order, together with a transformative or soteriological practice. Both must be present. A political movement may have ritual, doctrine, ethics and community and still fail both, because its ultimate is not treated as sacred and it offers no release from a diagnosed predicament.

The repair earns its keep by doing real classificatory work in both directions. It admits Buddhism, whose diagnosis of suffering and path to its cessation satisfy the soteriological condition exactly; Jainism, with bondage by karmic matter and release into the perfected state; Mīmāṃsā, with injunction, merit and a promised fruit; and Sāṃkhya, with entanglement and isolation. And it **excludes Cārvāka**, which denies the whole supersensible order and offers no path - an exclusion that shows the criterion is not merely permissive.

The alternative to functionalism is worse. A substantive definition centred on a personal creator settles a comparative question by stipulation, excluding Buddhism before examining it; and it cannot explain why traditions that lack a creator nonetheless possess doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience, narrative and institution in the pattern Smart identified.

A residual concession remains. Civil religion and secular spirituality sit uncomfortably close to the boundary, and the cluster classifies them only after asking whether a transformative discipline is present. That is a real cost of any functional account, but it is the cost of a working definition rather than of an empty one.

The charge therefore fails against the cluster while succeeding against unrestricted functionalism, which is precisely why the definition must be stated with its restrictions in the opening paragraph.

Why this earns marks: Concedes the true half explicitly; states the two load-bearing conditions; demonstrates classification in both directions; shows the substantive alternative is worse; ends with a residual concession rather than a clean sweep.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Assess the claim that dharma, *nirvāṇa* and *apūrva* are simply God under other names.

Model solution: This is the hidden-God objection, and it is the most persistent challenge to the whole clause. It infers, from the fact that a non-theistic concept performs a function God performs, that the concept is a disguised deity.

The inference is invalid, and the reply must say why rather than merely deny it. Functional similarity does not establish ontological identity. An impersonal law is not an omniscient person. Liberation reached by insight is not grace bestowed by an agent. A potency postulated to connect act and fruit does not select, forgive, respond or love. Each of these differences is not a matter of degree but of kind.

Take the three concepts in turn. *Dharma* in Buddhism is the order the path discloses and conforms to; it issues no commands, hears no petitions and grants no pardons. *Nirvāṇa* is the cessation of the conditions of suffering; it is a goal, not an agent, and it plays no cosmological role - treating it as a first cause reimports precisely the structure Buddhism dispenses with. *Apūrva* is explicitly a postulate introduced to bridge a perished act and a later fruit, and the Mīmāṃsā reply to Nyāya is that the connection is law-like rather than deliberative.

The objector has a comeback worth stating. If these concepts are doing the work God did, the tradition has acknowledged that the work must be done, so the theist's diagnosis of what religion requires was correct even if his ontology was not. That is a fair point and should be conceded: religion does require a sacred order, an account of moral consequence and a goal. What it does not require is that these be unified in a single responsive person.

Two disciplinary consequences follow for an answer. First, avoid writing that *Dharma* "takes the place of" God; describe instead what work it does and what work it does not do. Second, notice that the objection is strongest exactly where the theistic goods are relational - petition and grace - and weakest where they are structural.

The claim therefore fails as stated, while identifying correctly the functions any religion must discharge somehow.

Why this earns marks: Names the objection and its inference; refutes the inference with three kind-differences; treats the three concepts separately; concedes the objector's strongest comeback; converts the analysis into two writing rules.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Religion can survive the loss of God, but not the loss of a sacred order." Critically examine with reference to both Indian and modern Western positions.

Model solution: The statement is defensible, and examining it requires a criterion, two bodies of evidence and a boundary case.

The criterion. Religion is a socially embodied and disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order, expressed through some combination of doctrine, ritual, ethical formation, experience and community, and directed at a transformative or soteriological goal. Two conditions are load-bearing: the sacred order and the transformative practice. Creator-belief is one historically powerful way of organising the orientation, not a condition of it - and a definition that made it a condition would settle a comparative question by stipulation.

The Indian evidence: survival without God. Buddhism diagnoses suffering, explains its arising through dependent origination and karma, prescribes the Eightfold Path, sustains a community and completes in *nirvāṇa*. Jainism argues against a creator from motive and embodiment while retaining eternal souls, karmic matter, vows and the perfected *siddha* - an achieved rather than a governing divinity. Mīmāṃsā keeps scripture, ritual, duty and merit while making the Veda authorless and postulating unseen potency (*apūrva*) to connect act and fruit; Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* 1.1.2 makes dharma knowable from injunction alone. Classical Sāṃkhya derives the world-process from nature in proximity to plural selves and seeks isolation; Yoga's special self is not a creator and must not be read back into Sāṃkhya.

In every case what survives the removal of God is precisely a sacred order plus a path.

The modern Western evidence: the thinner case. Religious naturalism relocates ultimacy inside nature. Dewey's *A Common Faith* (1934) distinguishes "religion" from "the religious" and redefines God as the active relation between the ideal and the actual; Dworkin's *Religion without God* (2013) defends religious atheism on objective life-meaning

and cosmic sublimity; Goodenough's *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998) develops reverence for natural depth. Religious fictionalism goes further, declining to assert the claims at all: Cupitt's non-realism (1980) and Le Poidevin's fictionalism (1996) retain narrative, liturgy and formation without metaphysical assent.

These are genuinely religious on the criterion where a community and a transformative practice accompany the philosophy; where they do not, "religious" survives chiefly as an adjective for a quality of experience. Fictionalism additionally faces the sincerity objection, since prayer seems directed to a believed hearer. Advaita's two levels supply the instructive contrast: worship of the qualified absolute is efficacious at the everyday level and is **sublated**, not falsified, at the ultimate level - graded truth rather than pretence.

The boundary case. Cārvāka closes the epistemic route to every supersensible object: perception alone is a means of knowledge, concomitance cannot be established, consciousness is emergent, and order follows from own-nature. It therefore has no soteriology, no sacred, no community of practice and no ultimate concern. What results is not a godless religion but no religion at all - which is the strongest single confirmation of the statement under examination.

The qualification. "Survive" understates a real cost. Petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God, and traditions without them have a differently shaped devotional life. And the sacred-order condition needs policing at the modern boundary, since civil religion and secular spirituality display ritual and ultimate concern without a transformative discipline.

The statement therefore holds: God is separable from religion, a sacred order is not.

Why this earns marks: States a criterion before assembling evidence; runs Indian and Western bodies of evidence separately and comparably; uses Cārvāka as the confirming boundary; names the defeater - the devotional cost - that qualifies the verdict; ends by deciding rather than summarising.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the classical Indian non-theistic traditions with modern religious naturalism and fictionalism as answers to the question whether religion requires God.

Model solution: Both answer "no", but they arrive from opposite directions, and the comparison is decided by what each has to build and what each already possessed.

What is removed, and what replaces it. Buddhism removes creator and permanent self, replacing them with dependent origination, *Dharma*, *Śaṅgha* and *nirvāṇa*. Jainism removes only the creator, replacing it with karmic matter, vows and the perfected *siddha*. Mīmāṃsā removes both the author of the Veda and the dispenser of fruit, replacing them with authorless authority (*apauruṣeya*) and unseen potency (*apūrva*). Sāṃkhya removes the creator, replacing it with nature's evolution in proximity to plural selves and release as isolation. Religious naturalism removes supernatural ontology, replacing it with nature as the locus of ultimacy. Fictionalism removes assertion itself, replacing it with participation in a non-assertoric spirit.

The structural difference. The Indian systems are **positive** systems: they possess doctrines of causation, moral consequence, community and a final goal that were never derived from theism and therefore lose nothing when theism is withdrawn. Buddhism does not retain Christian forms after withdrawing belief; it has its own diagnosis, its own causal account and its own soteriology. The modern positions are **reconstructive**: they must build or re-motivate ultimacy after inherited metaphysics has weakened. That is why they are thinner, and the thinness is structural rather than accidental.

The sincerity test. Fictionalism's characteristic liability is sincerity: worship seems directed to a believed hearer, and make-believe worship risks being either dishonest or hollow. The fictionalist replies that transparent imaginative immersion is a familiar and non-deceptive human capacity, and that ritual can express commitment rather than report ontology; whether motivation survives over time is an unresolved empirical and existential issue. The comparative point that earns marks is that **Indian systems offer graded truth where Western fictionalism offers pretence**. Advaita treats worship of the qualified absolute as efficacious at the everyday level and sublated, not falsified, at the ultimate level; Buddhism's two truths permit serious conventional practice while denying ultimate substantial reference. Sublation is not falsification, and that difference preserves the practitioner's sincerity.

Where the modern positions are stronger. They address a question the classical traditions never faced: whether someone committed to a naturalistic ontology can be religious at all. Dewey's separation of "religion" from "the religious", Dworkin's religious atheism grounded in objective life-meaning and cosmic sublimity, and Goodenough's

reverence for natural depth are answers to that specific modern predicament, and the Indian systems have nothing to say to it directly.

The shared result, and the shared limit. Both families show that the *functions* of religion - reverence, community, ritual, orientation to ultimacy, self-transformation - are detachable from theistic belief. Both leave untouched the specifically relational goods: petition, covenant and grace still require a responsive God. And whether what survives counts as religion depends on the definition adopted at the start, which is why this clause always returns to the substantive-versus-functional question.

The classical traditions therefore give the stronger evidence that religion without God is actual; the modern positions give the sharper test of whether it remains possible under a naturalistic ontology.

Why this earns marks: Uses a removal-and-replacement bench for six routes; identifies the positive/reconstructive asymmetry as the structural difference; runs the sincerity test with the Indian graded-truth control; concedes where the modern positions are stronger; closes on the shared result and the shared limit.

Timed-paper compression plan

This clause owns seven parts across 2018-2025 and is absent as a primary owner only in 2022, so the compression problem is predictable and the plan below is question-shaped rather than generic.

If the stem is	Cut first	Never cut
a justification stem (2018)	the modern Western material; the second and third Indian cases down to a clause each	the stated definition; one Indian case with its mechanism; the boundary that excludes Cārvāka
an opponent-construction stem (2019)	your own preferred definition down to one sentence	the theist's five arguments; the Mīmāṃsā answer to allotment; the devotional concession
a necessity stem (2020)	Sāṃkhya; the naturalism/fictionalism paragraph	the substantive definition's best defence; one counterexample defended against reinterpretation
a possibility stem (2021)	comparative breadth; the Western comparison entirely	one tradition in depth as a <i>lived</i> practice; the concession about petition and grace
a definition-plus-position stem (2023)	adjacent positions (Kant, Spencer)	the weak/strong subdivision; the second printed deliverable; the reduction objection
a state-and-evaluate stem (2024)	the Jain and Mīmāṃsā parallels	the complete statement before evaluation; the devotional-Mahāyāna answer; the graded verdict
an argument-of-the-critique stem (2025)	the four-element ontology; the hedonist material entirely	the four moves of the concomitance problem; the conditioning-factor residue; both replies to self-refutation

The 60-second recovery drill. If time is collapsing, write four sentences in this order and stop: (1) the definition of religion you are using; (2) one tradition, with the mechanism that replaces the divine function; (3) the strongest theistic objection, named; (4) the graded verdict, with the cost you concede. Four correct sentences of this shape outscore two pages of school-listing.

What not to over-study. Do not let "spiritual but not religious" discourse, civil religion or the biography of the Western critics crowd out Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and the Indian anti-creator arguments. Master the definition test, one concrete tradition in depth, the theist's best objection and the exact verdict.

Self-scoring and next steps

Diagnostic score (out of 32)	Reading it	What to do next
28-32	the discriminations are secure	practise under time: a 15-marker and a 20-marker back to back, 45 minutes total
22-27	content is present, discriminations are soft	re-run the traps for every item missed, then rewrite one model answer from memory
15-21	the definition test is not yet automatic	re-read register cards 1-3 and the graded verdict ladder before attempting more questions
below 15	non-theism, atheism and agnosticism are being confused	return to the learning session's Basic block, Sessions 1-4; do not attempt timed answers yet

Trap census by cluster. Of the thirty-two examiner traps in this workbook, six concern the definition test and the criteria cluster, five concern the Buddhist material and the devotional complication, six concern Mīmāṃsā (authorless scripture, the sūtra, the postulate and the two schools), six concern Cārvāka (the concomitance argument, attribution discipline, the replies and the classification), three concern Jainism and Sāṃkhya-Yoga, three concern the four negative positions and agnosticism's two deliverables, and three concern the modern naturalism/fictionalism discriminations. A candidate who repeatedly misses one cluster should revise that cluster rather than attempt more mixed practice.

Independence note

Every model answer in Parts 3 and 4 is independent learner practice written to the repository's examiner-grade standard. UPSC does not publish official Mains answers or marking keys, and nothing here should be presented as one. The previous-year stems themselves are reproduced verbatim from the audited 2018-2025 Philosophy of Religion ledger, in which this clause owns seven question-parts and is absent as a primary owner only in 2022.